

MANAGING TECHNOLOGY

edited by Paula Warnken

• Academic Original Sin: Plagiarism, the Internet, and Librarians

Gail Wood, Guest Editor

Available online 9 April 2004

To paraphrase an early observer of networks, it is a truth universally acknowledged that[1] plagiarism is rampant among college undergraduates and the Internet is to blame; such a statement has been made so often in recent times that it almost seems to be a universal truth. Plagiarism is a contentious issue that needs to be examined closely, and this means we must look beyond the surface realities to the underlying causes in order to find remedies that are in keeping with the academic goals of respecting the scholarship of others and fostering new ideas in college students. Librarians can play a strong role in the ongoing discussions of academic integrity and academic dishonesty on college campuses.

BACKGROUND

As director of libraries at SUNY Cortland in Cortland, NY, I serve as an administrator in the Academic Affairs Division. In 2000, I was appointed chair of the Academic Grievance Tribunal (AGT) by the provost and vice president for academic affairs. As tribunal chair, I became the administrative designee for the provost who is charged with maintaining academic integrity on campus. I was to convene the hearings for charges of academic dishonesty and to send the tribunal's recommendations of guilty or not guilty to the provost for final judgment. As part of the process for upholding academic integrity,[2] the tribunal is composed of students and faculty. As the administrative representative, I vote only to break a tie. My role is intended to be administrative: coordinating hearings; ensuring confidentiality; facilitating paperwork and writing the tribunal's recommendations; and communicating with the provost concerning the grievance process.

Over the years as AGT chair, I have heard all the cases where the accused student has denied the charges of academic dishonesty. This process has opened my eyes to the situation of academic dishonesty and academic integrity on our campus and on other campuses. Before my appointment, my interaction with faculty and administrators concerning plagiarism was as a kind of antiplagiarism enforcer, where I assisted faculty in tracking down sources in cases of alleged plagiarism, or I made final recommendations in cases involving damaged library materials. Also, at the request of the Academic Writing Department, along with other SUNY Cortland librarians, I began to incorporate some information about citing sources into the Composition Library Instruction Program.

Serving as AGT chair sharpened my understanding of faculty and their relationships to research, textual analysis, teaching, and the stimulation of new ideas. I was also able to sharpen my view of the students' world and their relationship to information and the technology that underpins their lives. Over the years, I have consulted with faculty as they wrestle with academic dishonesty and its consequences. I have counseled students on the procedures and on the consequences of their actions. I have served as a resource person in the wider campus discussions and debates on academic integrity.

With these expanded views of the academic world in which the library provides support and partnerships, I was able to see that librarians could assume a strong, active role in the process of modeling academic integrity within the institution. I believe that librarians can serve as more than just ''plagiarism busters,'' but this does require that librarians improve their own knowledge of the debates concerning academic integrity. With an understanding of the world of information as viewed and manipulated by students, the college librarian is able to actively promote a more complex understanding of the Internet, electronic databases, and a critical approach to research and writing.

In the cases that I have heard on academic dishonesty, I am more convinced than ever that a librarian's understanding of the Internet and the flow of scholarly information would be helpful in not only avoiding academic dishonesty, but also in developing a strong expressive voice in the student-scholar, one who uses information wisely and appropriately in support of original ideas. While I have seen outright, flaunted dishonesty, more often than not I see a disparity between the values of academic integrity espoused by the institution and its faculty and the student who has committed an act of academic dishonesty. This disparity is not because students are more dishonest or lack a moral center, but that their experiences—particularly with Web-based transfer of information—has led them to form different attitudes towards information, authorship, and intellectual property. About students and their reactions in the

Gail Wood is Director of Libraries, SUNY Cortland, Cortland, NY 13045, USA <woodg@cortland.edu>.